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GOP establishes foothold in S.E. Mass.

Voters shifting away from Democrats on kitchen-table issues, regulations

By Chris Van Buskirk
GLOBE STAFF

NEW BEDFORD — Shawn Oliver, a local city councilor running for lieutenant governor, stood in front of a row of fishing boats in this coastal city on Tuesday to pitch voters on why they should back him and his gubernatorial running mate

Brian Shortsleeve.

The Republicans, he said, understood voters' fiscal hardships. Their South Coast "economic plan," Oliver said, would revitalize the region's ports. And they'd fight "unfair" regulations on commercial fishermen.

"The people in southeastern Massachusetts work hard," he said. But, "we're too often left behind."

The location, as much as the message, was a strategic one.

Situated astride two reddening counties, southeastern Massachusetts is slowly transforming into fertile political ground for Republicans, offering a haven for local conservatives amid the party's muted influence on deep-blue Beacon Hill. It's also made the region more than just a pit stop on the statewide campaign trail, but a potential foothold for the GOP to grow.

President Trump made some of

his strongest gains in Massachusetts in Bristol and Plymouth counties, the two areas where he performed the best in 2024. The Massachusetts Republican Party flipped a state Senate seat in the area that same year after it had been held by Democrats for decades. And some of the state's few remaining Republican county officials hold elected office in the region.

"That is the hotbed of the Republican Party in Massachusetts today,"

GOP, Page A6

Another pothole for those going electric

Insurers are charging more or dropping EV policies

By Aaron Pressman
GLOBE STAFF

Ron Eastman got an unpleasant surprise from the insurance company that has provided coverage for his electric vehicle, a Polestar 2 sedan, and a previous electric hybrid for more than a decade.

"The 2023 Polestar vehicle . . . does not meet company underwriting guidelines," the notice

from the insurer, Quincy Mutual, read. "This vehicle is electric and not eligible for coverage."

A 76-year-old retired professor, Eastman said he's never before had an issue with Quincy Mutual, "which is why I was very surprised when I got those letters. It's like, wow, what's going on?"

What's going on is that electric vehicles are often so much more expensive to repair than gas-powered cars that insurers are either charging significantly higher premiums

or, in extreme cases such as Eastman's, even dropping coverage altogether. This comes at a time when Massachusetts is already falling behind on its goal of persuading nearly 1 million drivers to switch from gas-powered cars to help cut climate emissions.

Massachusetts has the highest difference in insurance costs between electric vehicles and gas-powered: \$3,560 on average, for EVs in 2025, compared with \$2,318 for gas-powered cars, according to rankings from Insurify, which compares insurance rates.

CAR INSURANCE, Page A10

BIG NUMBERS

\$3,560

Average cost of insurance for an EV

\$2,318

Average cost of insurance for gas-powered cars

171,000

Number of EVs and plug-in hybrids on the road in Massachusetts



DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

Lillie Bryan, 79, of Dorchester says the rule change limiting bags has restricted her access to the grocery store.

Policy shift frustrates RIDE users

Disabled and older clients of authority's service say new rules leave them holding the bag

By Diti Kohli
GLOBE STAFF

For a decade, Lillie Bryan could count on the MBTA's paratransit service, The RIDE, to get her from home to the supermarket and food pantry with a full load of groceries every month.

But lately, the 79-year-old Dorchester resident has rationed her shopping outings and bought far fewer items because of a novel policy that requires RIDE customers to empty and collapse their foldable shopping carts. Limited to what she could carry, Bryan said she feared being stranded without a ride if she exceeded the restrictions.

"I had anxiety sitting there not knowing if I could get home with my food," Bryan said. "It's just really making you feel like you don't matter."

Implemented last August, the rules have radically upended the routines of some RIDE customers, people with disabilities who have few options to get around otherwise. They used to be able to stow all their shopping either in the rear of a van or the trunk of a RIDE sedan, but patrons must now fit their folded carts and belongings within their own sitting area, often jammed in by their feet or resting on their stomachs.

So widespread is the frustration over the rules that more than 50 RIDE patrons showed up at an MBTA board meeting this month wear-

THE RIDE, Page A10

School librarian hopes protest speaks volumes

Decision to quit over screen time sparks reflection

By Brooke Hauser
GLOBE STAFF

EASTHAMPTON — What's the point of a school librarian if students aren't reading?

That's the existential — and controversial — question posed by Nicholas Ames, the sole librarian at Easthampton High School, who recently asked the school board for a one-year unpaid leave of absence to call attention to what he says is a troubling decline in reading among students who are glued to their

screens.

Students rarely use the library to check out books, Ames said in a phone interview. Instead, he said, they scroll TikTok or Snapchat with friends.

In the last two school years, the library checked out just one or two books a month to students for pleasure reading, he said.

"It kept getting more and more demoralizing to the point where it's just like, well, what am I?," he said. "I'm not a librarian here, I'm a . . . whatever. I haven't come up with a good term for it."

Ames, 43, thought his quiet protest might drive support in

LIBRARIAN, Page A7

TREASURED ISLAND



LANE TURNER/GLOBE STAFF

A girl held tight to a Puerto Rico flag from the sunroof of a passing car during the annual Boston Puerto Rican Festival parade on Seaver Street Sunday. **B1.**

Glowing, glowing gone

Monday: Sunny, pleasant. High 74-79, low 64-69.

Tuesday: Early sun, late rain. High 75-80, low 64-69.

Weather and comics, **D4-5.** Obituaries, **C9.**

Sox trade for some lumber

The deal for slugger Curtis Mead (right) came together quickly. **C1.**



ASSOCIATED PRESS

Maine's attorney general backs the effort by the family of an immigrant killed by an ICE agent to receive a visa given to victims of certain crimes. B1.

The United States and Iran again paused their attacks amid diplomatic efforts. A3.

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